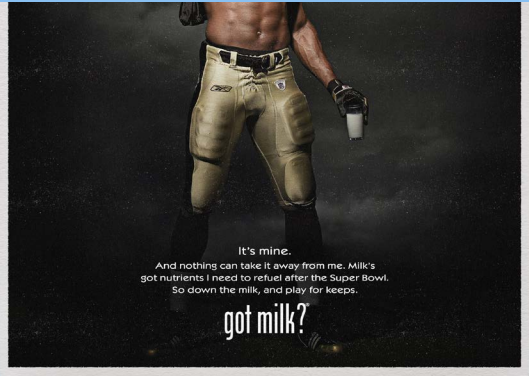






These "agricultural commodity checkoff programs," as they came to be called, were rooted in the idea that the government shouldn't solve surpluses by having farmers produce less. Instead, farmers could help fund efforts to convince consumers to buy more of their products. In her 2016 history "The Incredible, Edible Checkoff," Sarah Milov, history professor at University of Virginia, described this shift in thinking as "the national stomach, rather than the national purse, [underwriting] American agriculture."

Checkoff programs became the new normal. In the '80s and early '90s they exploded, resulting in a flood of food advertisements that anyone who tuned in at the time will recognize: "The Incredible, Edible Egg," "Pork: The Other White Meat," and "Beef: It's What's for Dinner," to name a few.

The dairy industry didn't get one checkoff program—it got many, a near-impenetrable morass of organizations with generic-sounding names (case in point: Dairy Management Inc.). The boom started with the federal Dairy Production Stabilization Act of 1983, which required farmers to pay 15 cents for every 100 pounds of milk (11.6 gallons) they produced to fund research, product development, and advertising. Then came MilkPEP (funded by a checkoff for milk buyers) and the California state equivalent, the California Milk Processor Board, established in 1993.

In the early '90s, California's milk industry was sweating about the future. Nationally, milk consumption had declined almost 20 percent over the previous two decades, down to less than one cup per person per day.

Hoping to curb the crisis, the California Milk Processor Board hired an ad exec named Jeff Manning, whom they tasked with rebranding the beverage. But the problem, as Manning writes in Got Milk? The Book, wasn't the public perception of milk—90



